

National University of Zoland

Diploma in Social Science Studies

Cultural perspective On Social Organization II (DSSS-105)

Department of Anthropology

**Educational Migration and Cultural Adaptation: Experiences of Myanmar Students in
Chiang Mai, Thailand**

Mr. Win Moe

Date: 28 July 2026

Contents

Abstract.....	3
I. Introduction.....	4
1.1 Background of the Study	
1.2 Significance of the Study	
1.3 Research Objectives	
1.4 Research Questions	
II. Literature Review.....	5
III. Methodology.....	6
3.1 Research Design	
3.2 Population and Sample	
3.3 Research Instruments	
3.4 Data Collection Procedure	
3.5 Data Analysis	
3.6 Ethical Considerations	
IV. Findings.....	9
V. Discussion and Conclusion.....	12
5.1 Discussion	
5.2 Conclusion	
VI. References.....	14

Abstract

This study explores the experiences of educational migration and cultural adaptation among Myanmar students studying in Chiang Mai, Thailand. Following political instability and educational disruptions in Myanmar, many students have sought educational opportunities abroad. This research aims to identify the factors influencing Myanmar students' decisions to study in Chiang Mai, examine their adaptation experiences, and explore how they maintain their cultural identity while living in Thailand. A mixed-methods approach was employed, combining survey questionnaires administered to 20 Myanmar students and semi-structured interviews conducted with 5 students. The findings reveal that political instability, scholarship opportunities, affordable tuition fees, and the peaceful environment of Chiang Mai were major factors influencing educational migration. Students faced challenges related to language barriers, homesickness, and cultural differences but gradually adapted through social support networks, university activities, and increased cultural understanding. Despite adapting to Thai society, participants actively maintained their Myanmar cultural identity through language, cultural practices, and community engagement. The study contributes to understanding educational migration and cultural adaptation among Myanmar students in Thailand and highlights the importance of supportive educational environments for international students.

Keywords: *Educational Migration, Cultural Adaptation, Myanmar Students, Identity, Chiang Mai, Thailand*

Acknowledgements

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to my advisor, Tr. Kalyar and Tr. Mal Shin, for their continuous guidance, encouragement, and valuable feedback throughout this research. I also extend my appreciation to all participants who generously shared their experiences and insights.

I. Introduction

1.1 Background of the Study

Educational migration has become an increasingly important phenomenon in Southeast Asia as students seek better educational opportunities, personal development, and international experiences. In recent years, political instability and educational disruptions in Myanmar have significantly influenced the movement of students to neighboring countries, particularly Thailand. Chiang Mai has emerged as a popular destination due to its affordable cost of living, quality educational institutions, cultural similarities, and geographical proximity to Myanmar.

The migration of students is not solely an educational process but also a cultural experience. Students who move abroad must adapt to new social norms, educational systems, languages, and lifestyles while maintaining aspects of their original cultural identity. Cultural adaptation is therefore an essential aspect of educational migration and influences students' academic success, social integration, and overall well-being.

Previous studies have shown that Myanmar students studying in Thailand often experience language barriers, academic challenges, and sociocultural adjustment difficulties (Soe & Charoenroop, 2025). Similarly, educational migration among Myanmar youth has been influenced by political instability, limited educational opportunities, and aspirations for international exposure (Zin, 2025). While existing research has explored migration and adaptation among Myanmar and Shan migrant populations in Thailand, limited studies have specifically examined the combined experiences of educational migration and cultural adaptation among Myanmar university students in Chiang Mai.

This study seeks to address this gap by investigating the experiences of Myanmar students studying in Chiang Mai, Thailand. Understanding these experiences can contribute to anthropological discussions on migration, identity, and cultural adaptation while providing practical insights for educational institutions supporting international students.

1.2 Significance of the Study

This study contributes to the understanding of educational migration and cultural adaptation among Myanmar students in Thailand. The findings may benefit educational institutions, policymakers, and student support services by providing insights into the challenges and needs of international students. Furthermore, the study contributes to anthropological discussions on migration, identity formation, and cultural adaptation in contemporary Southeast Asia.

1.3 Research Objectives

This study aims to achieve the following objectives:

- To identify the factors influencing Myanmar students' decisions to study in Chiang Mai, Thailand.
- To examine the cultural and academic challenges experienced by Myanmar students.
- To explore how Myanmar students adapt to Thai society and university life.
- To investigate how Myanmar students maintain their cultural identity while studying in Thailand.

1.4 Research Questions

This study is guided by the following research questions:

1. What factors influence Myanmar students to study in Chiang Mai, Thailand?
2. What cultural and academic challenges do Myanmar students experience?
3. How do Myanmar students adapt to life in Chiang Mai?
4. How do Myanmar students maintain their cultural identity while studying in Thailand?

II. Literature Review

Educational migration refers to the movement of students across national borders to pursue educational opportunities. For many Myanmar students, educational migration has become increasingly significant due to political instability and disruptions to higher education within Myanmar. Zin (2025) found that political uncertainty, military conscription concerns, and limited

educational opportunities were major factors motivating Myanmar youth to pursue studies in Northern Thailand. Similarly, Win (2008) reported that migrant Burmese students viewed education as a pathway toward personal development, improved career opportunities, and social mobility.

Cultural adaptation is a central aspect of the migration experience. Students who migrate to a new country must learn to navigate unfamiliar social norms, languages, and educational systems. Soe and Charoenroop (2025) found that Myanmar postgraduate students in Thailand commonly experienced language barriers and academic adjustment difficulties during their early stages of study. However, participants gradually adapted through language learning, peer support, and increased engagement with their educational environment.

The concept of cultural hybridity provides an important perspective for understanding adaptation. According to the study on second-generation Shan migrants in Thailand (2021), migrants often combine elements of both their original and host cultures rather than completely abandoning one identity for another. This process allows individuals to develop flexible cultural identities while maintaining connections to their heritage. Similar findings were reported in the study of Shan youth adaptation through education, which emphasized the role of educational institutions in supporting cultural integration while preserving cultural identity (2023).

Existing literature suggests that educational migration involves more than academic advancement. It includes social adaptation, identity negotiation, language acquisition, and cultural transformation. However, few studies have specifically focused on Myanmar university students in Chiang Mai and how they simultaneously experience educational migration and cultural adaptation in the post-2021 context. Therefore, this study seeks to contribute to the growing body of research on migration and identity in Southeast Asia.

III. Methodology

This study employs a mixed-method research design to explore the educational migration and cultural adaptation experiences of Myanmar students studying in Chiang Mai, Thailand. The mixed-method approach combines both quantitative and qualitative data to provide a comprehensive understanding of the research topic. The quantitative component identifies

general patterns and trends among Myanmar students, while the qualitative component provides deeper insights into their personal experiences, challenges, and adaptation strategies.

3.1 Research Design

A mixed-method design was selected because it allows the researcher to examine both statistical trends and individual experiences related to educational migration and cultural adaptation. The quantitative data were collected through structured questionnaires to identify the factors influencing students' decisions to study in Chiang Mai, their adaptation experiences, and perceptions of cultural differences. Meanwhile, qualitative data were obtained through semi-structured interviews to explore participants' personal experiences, motivations, challenges, and identity maintenance in greater depth. Combining both approaches strengthens the validity of the findings through data triangulation.

3.2 Population and Sample

The target population of this study consists of Myanmar students currently studying in Chiang Mai, Thailand. The sample includes 20 Myanmar students who meet the following criteria: (1) they are citizens of Myanmar, (2) they are currently enrolled in a university or educational institution in Chiang Mai, and (3) they have lived in Chiang Mai for at least six months.

This study uses purposive sampling, a non-probability sampling technique, to select participants who have direct experience with educational migration and cultural adaptation. Purposive sampling is appropriate because it focuses on individuals who can provide relevant and meaningful information regarding the research topic.

In addition to the survey participants, five students were selected for in-depth interviews, consisting of three male students and two female students. These participants were selected based on their willingness to participate and their ability to share detailed experiences related to studying and living in Chiang Mai.

3.3 Research Instruments

This study utilizes two main research instruments: a structured questionnaire and a semi-structured interview guide.

For the quantitative component, a structured questionnaire was developed and distributed through Google Forms. The questionnaire consists of four sections. The first section collects demographic information such as gender, age, educational background, and length of residence in Chiang Mai. The second section examines factors influencing educational migration, including educational opportunities, political circumstances, scholarship opportunities, and safety concerns. The third section focuses on cultural adaptation experiences, language barriers, cultural differences, and social integration. The final section explores identity maintenance, support systems, and personal development. The questionnaire includes multiple-choice questions, Likert-scale items, and open-ended questions.

For the qualitative component, a semi-structured interview guide was used. The interview questions were designed to align with the research objectives and research questions. The semi-structured format allowed participants to discuss their migration experiences, adaptation challenges, cultural identity, support systems, and future aspirations while providing flexibility for follow-up questions.

3.4 Data Collection Procedure

Data collection was conducted over a one-week period. The questionnaire was distributed online through Google Forms to the selected participants. Before completing the survey, participants were informed about the purpose of the study and assured that their participation was voluntary. They were also informed that their responses would remain anonymous and confidential.

For the qualitative component, semi-structured interviews were conducted with five selected participants. The interviews were carried out through online communication platforms and face-to-face meetings, depending on participant availability. Each interview lasted approximately 20–30 minutes. With participants' permission, the interviews were recorded to ensure accuracy during data analysis.

3.5 Data Analysis

The quantitative data collected from the questionnaires were analyzed using descriptive statistics, including frequencies and percentages. These statistical methods were used to identify patterns related to educational migration, cultural adaptation, language barriers, identity maintenance, and support systems. The findings were presented through tables and charts to facilitate interpretation.

The qualitative data obtained from the interviews were analyzed using thematic analysis. The researcher reviewed the interview transcripts multiple times to identify recurring themes and patterns. Key themes related to migration motivations, adaptation challenges, cultural identity, support networks, and personal growth were developed and interpreted. Selected quotations from participants were included in the findings section to support and enrich the quantitative results.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

This study follows ethical research principles to ensure the protection and well-being of participants. Participation in the study was voluntary, and participants had the right to withdraw from the study at any time without penalty. All responses were kept anonymous and confidential, and the data were used solely for academic purposes as part of the DSSS-105 Cultural Perspectives and Organization course at Payap University.

Before data collection, informed consent was obtained from all participants. Participants were informed about the objectives of the study, the procedures involved, and how the collected information would be used. To protect privacy, no personally identifiable information was included in the research findings. The researcher also ensured that the study followed the anthropological ethical principles of informed consent, confidentiality, respect for participants, and the commitment to do no harm.

IV. Findings

A total of 20 Myanmar students participated in the survey. Among them, 55% (11 students) were male and 45% (9 students) were female. Regarding educational background, 40% (8 students) had completed GED programs before enrolling in universities in Chiang Mai. Meanwhile, 35%

(7 students) had previously studied at universities in Myanmar, and 25% (5 students) were graduates of Mon National College.

The survey findings revealed several factors influencing students' decisions to study in Chiang Mai. The most common reason was the disruption of education in Myanmar due to the political situation, reported by 45% (9 students). Additionally, 25% (5 students) received scholarships that enabled them to pursue higher education in Thailand. Another 20% (4 students) stated that they wanted to improve their skills and gain international exposure by studying alongside students from different countries. The remaining 10% (2 students) identified safety concerns in Myanmar as the primary reason for seeking educational opportunities abroad.

When asked why they selected Chiang Mai, 50% (10 students) cited affordable tuition fees and living expenses. Another 30% (6 students) preferred Chiang Mai's peaceful environment compared to larger cities such as Bangkok. The remaining 20% (4 students) appreciated the affordable accommodation and supportive Myanmar community.

Regarding adaptation to life in Chiang Mai, 75% (15 students) reported that they had adapted successfully, while 20% (4 students) experienced moderate challenges. Only 5% (1 student) reported significant adaptation difficulties. Furthermore, 70% (14 students) experienced language barriers, particularly in daily communication outside the university. Twenty-five percent (5 students) reported occasional difficulties, while only 5% (1 student) experienced few communication problems.

The survey also revealed that 80% (16 students) noticed cultural differences in communication styles, classroom interactions, and social behavior. Despite these differences, 90% (18 students) agreed that they were able to maintain their Myanmar cultural identity while studying in Chiang Mai. Only 10% (2 students) reported some difficulty balancing adaptation and cultural preservation.

Participants identified several support systems that helped them adapt. Family support was mentioned by 80% (16 students), Myanmar friends by 75% (15 students), and university support services by 60% (12 students). In addition, 95% (19 students) believed that studying in Chiang Mai had positively influenced their personal growth and future opportunities.

Five students participated in semi-structured interviews. Through thematic analysis, five major themes emerged.

The first theme was educational opportunities beyond Myanmar. Four out of five participants (80%) explained that the political situation in Myanmar significantly disrupted their educational plans and encouraged them to seek opportunities abroad. Several participants stated that studying in Chiang Mai provided a stable educational environment that was unavailable in Myanmar at the time. Three participants (60%) also mentioned scholarship opportunities as a major motivation.

The second theme was affordability and accessibility of Chiang Mai. All participants (100%) emphasized that Chiang Mai was more affordable than many other international study destinations. Participants highlighted lower tuition fees, affordable accommodation, and a lower cost of living. Four participants (80%) also appreciated Chiang Mai's peaceful atmosphere and student-friendly environment.

The third theme was adaptation challenges and adjustment strategies. Three participants (60%) identified language barriers as their greatest challenge upon arrival. Four participants (80%) reported homesickness and difficulties adjusting to a new educational system. However, all participants (100%) stated that they gradually adapted through friendships, university activities, and increased exposure to Thai culture.

The fourth theme was maintaining cultural identity. All participants (100%) reported maintaining their Myanmar cultural identity through language use, traditional food, cultural celebrations, and participation in Myanmar student communities. Participants viewed adaptation as learning from another culture rather than abandoning their own.

The fifth theme was personal growth and future aspirations. All interview participants (100%) believed that studying in Chiang Mai contributed positively to their personal development. They reported becoming more independent, confident, and open-minded. Many participants also believed that their international educational experiences would improve future career opportunities.

V. Discussion and Conclusion

5.1 Discussion

The findings suggest that educational migration among Myanmar students is strongly connected to both structural and personal factors. Political instability emerged as the most significant factor influencing migration decisions. This data supports Zin (2025), who found that educational disruptions, political uncertainty, and limited opportunities in Myanmar encouraged many students to pursue education abroad. Similarly, the evidence supports Win (2008), who argued that migrant students often view education as a pathway toward social mobility and personal development.

Affordability was another important factor influencing students' decisions to study in Chiang Mai. Participants consistently highlighted lower tuition fees, affordable accommodation, and a lower cost of living compared to larger cities and other countries. These outcomes indicate that practical considerations play an important role in educational migration decisions.

The study also found that cultural adaptation was generally successful despite several challenges. Language barriers were among the most frequently reported difficulties. This finding is consistent with Soe and Charoenroop (2025), who found that Myanmar students often struggle with communication and academic adjustment when studying in Thailand. However, students in both studies gradually adapted through social interaction, language learning, and support networks.

Another important finding concerns identity maintenance. Rather than abandoning their cultural background, participants maintained their Myanmar identity while adapting to Thai society. This finding reflects the concept of cultural hybridity discussed in the study of second-generation Shan migrants (2021). Students demonstrated that adaptation does not necessarily require cultural assimilation. Instead, individuals can successfully integrate aspects of both cultures while preserving their original identity.

The results also support the study on Shan youth adaptation through education (2023), which emphasized the role of educational institutions in promoting social integration and cultural understanding. Universities in Chiang Mai provided opportunities for interaction, skill

development, and cultural exchange, helping students adapt successfully while maintaining connections to their cultural heritage.

Overall, the data suggests that educational migration is not solely an academic process. It is also a social and cultural experience that involves adaptation, identity negotiation, and personal growth. The experiences of Myanmar students demonstrate how migration can create opportunities for both educational advancement and intercultural learning.

5.2 Conclusion

This study explored the educational migration and cultural adaptation experiences of Myanmar students studying in Chiang Mai, Thailand. The study found that students chose to study in Chiang Mai for various reasons, including educational opportunities, scholarships, affordable living costs, and the political situation in Myanmar. Although they experienced challenges such as language barriers and cultural differences, most students were able to adapt successfully while maintaining their cultural identity.

This research shows that educational migration is not only about pursuing higher education in another country but also about adapting to a new cultural environment and developing new perspectives. From an anthropological perspective, culture plays an important role in shaping students' experiences, relationships, and identities. The study also demonstrates that cultural adaptation is a gradual process in which students learn to understand and respect a new culture while preserving their own traditions and values.

This study provides a better understanding of the educational migration experiences of Myanmar students in Chiang Mai and offers practical implications for universities seeking to improve support services for international students. It also contributes to the growing body of research on educational migration and cultural adaptation in Thailand. Finally, it is hoped that this study will serve as a useful reference for future researchers interested in migration, culture, and international education.

VI. References

- Soe, K., & Charoenroop, K. (2025). *Journey of Myanmar postgraduate students: Overcoming language barriers and academic challenges during study abroad programs in Thailand. Journal of Studies in the English Language*, 20(2).
<https://doi.org/10.64731/jsel.v20i2.279711>
- Tan, T. (2025). *Challenges in migration, education, and English as lingua franca: A case study of Myanmar youth in a private university in Northern Thailand. Theory and Practice in Language Studies*, 15(4), 1174–1182.
- Worawong, P. (2023). *The adaptation of Shan youth through education in Thailand. Graduate School Journal, Pibulsongkram Rajabhat University*, 17(2), 13–27.
- Yeesin, C. (2021). *Adaptation of the second generation of Shan migrants from Myanmar through cultural hybridity in Thailand. Political Science and Public Administration Journal*, 12(1), 75–97.
- Win, T. (2008). *Competency characteristics of migrant Burmese students studying at the Migrant Learning Center, Chiang Mai, Thailand* (Master's thesis). Chiang Mai University.